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The Catalyst Elon Musk's post on using weight-loss drugs created quite a buzz about the products

viding solutions and overcoming the stigma surrounding obesity. In plain speak: how does one tackle Indians' fondness for *gulab jamun*, *rosogolla*, and *samosa*?

Eli Lilly's Gupta highlights the need to recognise obesity as a chronic condition that requires comprehensive care. "It is important that obesity is viewed in the same way as other chronic diseases and that people living with obesity can access comprehensive care that can prevent and treat obesity. This includes lifestyle regimens such as diet and exercise, obesity management medications, and bariatric surgery," Gupta says.

Currently, weight-loss medications in India are limited to options like Orlistat and Liraglutide.

Orlistat, an anti-obesity drug, has been available in India since the early 2000s. It works by inhibiting the absorption of dietary fats in the intestine. Metformin, a diabetes medication, helps with weight management by improving insulin sensitivity and lowering blood sugar. Liraglutide, originally developed for diabetes, is used off-label at lower doses to assist with weight loss. Liraglutide for weight loss became available in India around 2017.

They have been used in India as part of weight-loss programmes, especially in the context of diabetes, but the newer stars are semaglutide and tirzepatide.

Reach for the Stars?

As Eli Lilly and Novo Nordisk prepare to launch their weight-loss treatments in India, cost is a big worry. In the US, Wegovy costs around \$1,000 monthly, making it unaffordable for most patients. A big downside: you can't stop taking it; most of your lost weight will return.

They can become affordable in India only if the pricing is adjusted, possibly through partnerships with generic manufacturers like Cipla or Sun Pharma.

This is where local pharmaceutical companies such as Dr. Reddy's Laboratories, Lupin, Zydus Cadila, and Sun Pharma can get into the act. And they are.

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories has received approval to conduct a bioequivalence study on semaglutide, while Zydus Cadila is developing its obesity treatment candidates. Sun Pharma is working on GLOO34, a long-acting GLP-1 receptor agonist for obese and non-obese adults without diabetes, which has shown positive results in early trials.

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories plans to expand its portfolio to include around 15 GLP-1 drugs, with different timelines for their development and release.

Biocon's Executive Chairperson, Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, has a word for the dual health crises of diabetes and obesity: Diabetesity. She highlights Biocon's unique position in offering a combination of insulins and GLP-1 receptor agonists and says, "Even in the biosimilars space, we are highly differentiated as the only company developing biosimilar insulins."

"We're already developing GLP-1s and achieved the first-ever approval for a GLP-1 peptide, liraglutide, in the UK. With semaglutide [Ozempic] going off-patent in emerging markets and Canada by 2026, there are immense opportunities. However, success will hinge on scale—not just in peptide production but also in developing the devices required to convert these into products," she says.

Biocon is also preparing to launch its liraglutide products in various regions as the drug goes off-patent in many parts of the world. Meanwhile, semaglutide, a once-weekly injection, represents the next generation of GLP-1s, with Novo Nordisk moving towards a monthly injection.

Road Ahead: Not So Smooth

Despite the promise of tirzepatide and semaglutide, their entry into the Indian market won't be smooth: there are regulatory hurdles.

In August 2024, the SEC reviewed Eli Lilly's proposal to import and market a multi-dose prefilled pen version of tirzepatide, branded as KwikPen, with dosages between